Backgammon

GB

Equipment needed for the game:
Board, 15 white coloured pieces (in the form of a disc) and 15 black ones, dice

Terminology:
Each player has an outfield and an infield on the board. The infield is also called the home field.

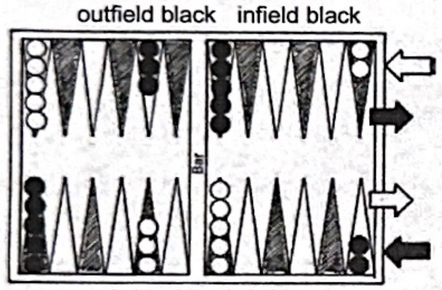
Bar: Separation of the playing fields, the halfway line.

Point: The (acute) point of a triangle on the board pointing toward the bar.

Aim of the game:
This is to bring home and remove one's own pieces from the board. The first player to take all his pieces off the board is the winner.

Basic set-up:
Since there are different ways to play Backgammon only the most well-known basic rules are explained here.
Pieces are shown in the following illustration in their starting position. White plays here from above right to left, then down the left and from there to the right into his home field i.e. anti-clockwise. Black moves in the other direction, clockwise. The given direction must be observed, moves in the opposite direction are not permitted.

outfield black infield black



outfield white infield white

Start:
To start the game; each player throws one dice to determine who makes the first move. The player with the higher number begins. If both players throw the same number the procedure is repeated, until one has a higher score. For the first move, the combined two scores of the dice thrown is used.

Throwing the dice:
After the start two dice are used for each throw. Both players take turns to throw and move. The dice must be thrown into each respective right-hand half of the board.

Move:
The pieces can be moved by the number shown on the dice thrown. One of two possibilities of move can be selected: One single move with the indicated numbers of both cubes added moving only one piece. In this case it must be noted that the numbers may not be simply added, the move must be split into two parts, one for each die, and an intermediate stop on a POINT must be possible. If the intermediate stop should be occupied by an opposing piece, then this move is illegal. It is up to the player however to select the order of the chosen die. In the other case the player moves with two different pieces.
Example: Thrown dice give a 2 and a 5. It is up to the player now to move a piece either 2 and 5 or 5 and 2 or to move with two different stones in each case 2 and 5 points.

To consider when moving:
All POINTS may be occupied, with exception of those on which two or more opposing pieces are standing. In principle the player is obliged to move thus both thrown dice be played. If it is only possible to move the one piece, then the higher of the two die numbers must be moved. The lower number is forfeited. If no piece can be moved, the move is completely forfeited and it is the opponent's turn.

Illegal moves:
If one player lays a piece wrongly, then the other player may require the correction of the move. The correction may take place only if the next throw has not already been taken.

Capturing pieces:
If a single piece is on a POINT, then this can be knocked onto the bar by the opponent by landing on this POINT or on making an intermediate stop. The captured piece is physically put on the bar.

Return of a piece into play: A player who has one or more pieces on the bar is not allowed to make moves in the playing field until all his pieces have been brought back into play, this being into the opponent's home field. Rules of return: Only if the piece on the bar can land on the unoccupied POINT in the opponent's home field determined by the number on the dice thrown. If a single opponent's piece occupies a POINT, it can be captured and so carried off to the bar during this move. If the player on the bar cannot make a legal move then this move is forfeited and it is the opponent's turn.

Double:
If a double is thrown the player moves twice as many points as shown on the dice.
Example: If a player throws a two on each die then he has the option of different combinations. He can move 2 points along, four times with only one piece; or three times 2 points with one and with another piece once 2 points; or with two pieces two times 2 points and with another piece also twice 2 points.

"Bearing off":
The bearing off may only be started if all 15 stones are in one's own home field. Bearing off is done by each player clearing his own pieces from the board by throwing the necessary numbers on the dice. A piece is moved off the board if the score on the dice is high enough to carry the piece over the edge of the board. One may use a part of the throw or the whole throw also to move other pieces into the home field instead of bearing off. This can be an astute move if the opponent still has a piece on the bar which could capture pieces and ban them to the bar. If a piece is knocked onto the bar while a player is bearing off, then he must bring this piece back into play and into his own home field again before he can continue with bearing off.

End of the game and profiting

Simple victory:
The winner is whoever bears off all his pieces before the opponent can clear his last piece from the board. Hereby the opponent could have cleared away several pieces.

Gammon profit:
The winner is the player who is first to bear off all his pieces whereby the opponent could not clear away any of his pieces.

Backgammon profit:
The winner is the player who is first to bear off all his pieces, hereby the opponent could not clear away any of his pieces and he still has one or more pieces on the bar or in the winner's home field.

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With some Backgammon versions a doubling cube is also used. The stake can be doubled during the game using this special die. This variant of the game and also the different tournament rules cannot be dealt with here.

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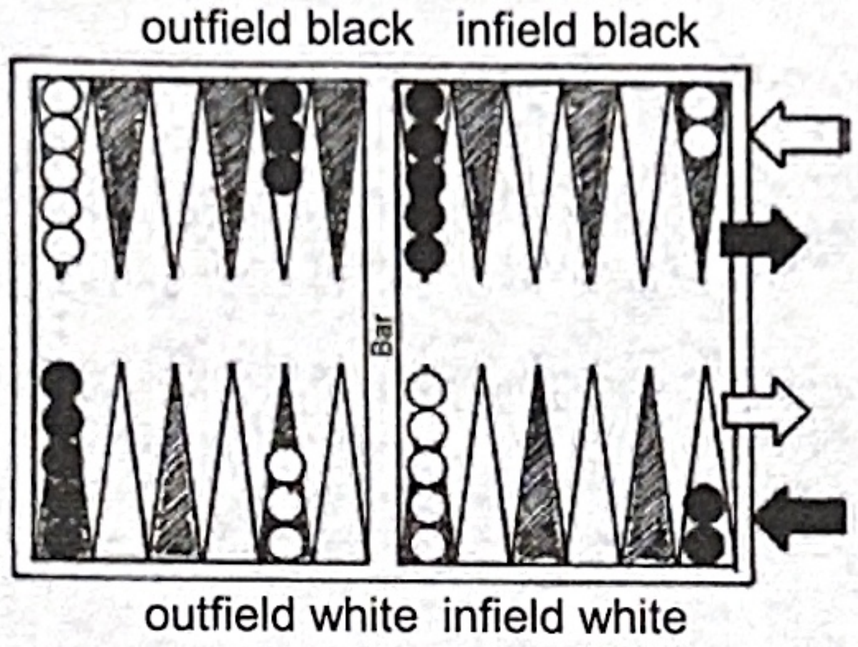
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